Haligric Research Integration Series

The Corn People and the Island Ancestors

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Maya, Taíno, and Garifuna Peoples of Mesoamerica and the Caribbean

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Three peoples whose gods and ancestors were declared destroyed by conquest, and three peoples who are still, today, practicing.

The Maya of Guatemala, Mexico, Belize, and Honduras trace humanity itself to a third divine attempt — after mud and wood both failed — made finally from corn. Their calendar keepers still count the days by an unbroken count that predates the conquest by over a thousand years.

The Taíno of the Greater Antilles were declared extinct in most textbooks for five centuries — and are, right now, publicly and organizedly insisting otherwise.

The Garifuna, exiled by the British from their island homeland in 1797 and scattered along the Central American coast, still call their ancestors home every year in an all-night ceremony that has outlasted the empire that tried to erase them.

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Introduction — Three Survivals

This volume covers three distinct traditions of Mesoamerica and the Caribbean, each chosen for being a genuine gap in this series' coverage rather than a repeat of existing material: the Maya, whose more than thirty living language communities span Guatemala, southern Mexico, Belize, and Honduras, and whose sacred tradition is distinct from the Aztec/Mexica material covered in this series' companion Serpent and Star volume; the Taíno, the Indigenous people of the Greater Antilles (Puerto Rico, Cuba, Hispaniola, Jamaica) at the time of European contact, long declared extinct in most historical accounts and now the subject of an active, organized cultural and religious revival; and the Garifuna, an Afro-Indigenous people descended from intermarriage between shipwrecked or escaped West African people and Island Carib communities on St. Vincent, exiled by the British in 1797 and now settled along the Caribbean coast of Honduras, Belize, Guatemala, and Nicaragua.

Each people's sacred tradition survived, in some form, a colonial process explicitly designed to erase it — through the burning of Maya codices, through the near-total demographic collapse of the Taíno population within a century of contact, and through the Garifuna's forced removal from their original homeland — and each survival looks different: Maya practice continues in direct, unbroken ceremonial lines in many highland communities; Taíno practice is being actively reconstructed and revived from historical and archaeological sources alongside living oral fragments; Garifuna practice, centered on the dügü ceremony described below, has been continuously performed without the same total rupture, making it in some respects the most intact of the three.

The Maya — The Popol Vuh and the Corn People

The Popol Vuh, the K'iche' Maya sacred narrative of highland Guatemala, was transcribed into Latin script by K'iche' nobles around 1554-1558, in the decades immediately following Spanish conquest and the systematic destruction of Maya bark-paper codices — the text survived specifically because it was preserved in writing rather than left in a form the conquerors could burn. It was later copied by the Dominican friar Francisco Ximénez around 1701, and this bilingual manuscript, now held at Chicago's Newberry Library, remains the primary source for the text today.

The Popol Vuh describes creation as an iterative, deliberate process: the gods — including Q'uq'umatz, the Feathered Serpent, and Huracán — first attempt to create humanity from mud, which dissolves, then from wood, which lacks a soul and is destroyed in a subsequent flood, and finally succeed in creating humanity from maize, since only the corn people possess the thought, speech, memory, and gratitude the gods intended; notably, the gods deliberately limit human vision and understanding at this final creation, a theological detail understood as establishing appropriate human humility before the divine.

The Hero Twins, Hunahpu and Xbalanque, are the Popol Vuh's central heroic figures: sons of an earlier defeated hero, they descend into Xibalba, the underworld, to confront its lords and avenge their father, defeating death itself through a combination of cleverness and voluntary self-sacrifice — allowing themselves to be killed and then resurrecting — before restoring their father as the Maize God and ascending to become the sun and moon, establishing the cosmic order under which the created world operates.

Maya Cosmology, Calendar, and Ceremony

Maya cosmology describes a layered universe of thirteen heavens and nine underworld levels, connected by a great world tree, often depicted as a ceiba, whose roots, trunk, and branches unite the underworld, the earthly plane, and the heavens. The Maya calendar system, comprising the 260-day Tzolk'in ritual calendar, the 365-day Haab' solar calendar, and the Long Count system used for tracking longer historical spans, remains among the most sophisticated calendrical systems developed anywhere in the pre-modern world, and continues to be actively maintained today by trained calendar specialists.

The Mesoamerican ballgame, played on masonry courts found at Maya sites throughout the region, combined athletic competition with cosmological reenactment, understood in some contexts as a ritual restaging of the Hero Twins' contest against the lords of Xibalba, with outcomes in some documented instances carrying life-and-death stakes for the losing side. Bloodletting rituals, performed by rulers and nobility using stingray spines or other implements, were understood as a necessary reciprocal offering sustaining the gods and the cosmic order, reflecting a broader Maya theological principle that human ritual obligation is required to maintain the world's continued functioning.

Contemporary Maya spiritual practitioners, known among the K'iche' as ajq'ijab' ('day-keepers'), continue to consult the 260-day sacred calendar for divination, naming ceremonies, and ritual timing, and actively teach and reference the Popol Vuh in ongoing ceremonial practice; UNESCO recognized the Popol Vuh as an element of Guatemala's Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2012, formally affirming its status as a living rather than purely historical text.

The Taíno — Cemís, Atabey, and the Living Ancestors

Taíno religion centered on cemís, sacred objects and the spirit-beings inhabiting them, understood as primordial ancestral guardians who could be consulted and who actively guided community life; Atabey, described as the great mother of the natural world, held a central place in Taíno cosmology as the source of earth's fertility and generative power, with Yúcahu recognized as a principal male deity associated with cassava (the staple crop) and the sea, and Guabancex understood as a storm deity representing Atabey's more destructive, transformative aspect.

The areíto, a combined ceremony of song, dance, and oral historical recitation, functioned as the central communal Taíno ritual practice, transmitting genealogy, cosmology, and historical memory across generations in a form that scholars have traced forward into elements of later syncretic Caribbean religious practice. The cohoba ceremony, involving the ritual inhalation of a psychoactive snuff prepared from cohoba tree seeds, was used specifically to induce trance states for direct communication with ancestral cemís and spirits, typically performed by behiques (Taíno religious specialists functioning as priest-healers) on behalf of the community.

Long treated in mainstream historical narrative as an extinct people following catastrophic population collapse in the century after 1492, the Taíno are today the subject of an active and organized cultural and religious revival centered in Puerto Rico, the Dominican Republic, Cuba, and diaspora communities in the United States; contemporary practitioners describe engaging directly with cemí veneration, cohoba and tobacco ceremony, and ancestor communication as living, reconstructed practice, explicitly framing Taíno identity and religion as continuous and surviving rather than a purely historical subject of study.

The Garifuna — Afro-Indigenous Synthesis and Exile

The Garifuna trace their origin to intermarriage, beginning in the seventeenth century, between West and Central African people — some escaped from slavery, some from shipwrecked slave vessels — and Island Carib and Arawak communities already established on the Caribbean island of St. Vincent, producing a distinct Afro-Indigenous people, language, and religious synthesis. Following armed resistance to British colonial expansion on St. Vincent, the British forcibly exiled the Garifuna population in 1797, deporting the great majority to the island of Roatán off the coast of Honduras, from which Garifuna communities subsequently spread along the Caribbean coast of Honduras, Belize, Guatemala, and Nicaragua, where most Garifuna communities are found today.

Garifuna religious cosmology centers on the gubida, ancestral spirits who remain actively engaged in the lives of their living descendants and who can cause illness when displeased or neglected, requiring ritual reconciliation; the buyei, a trained religious specialist analogous to but distinct from the Taíno behique, serves as healer, diviner, and ceremonial leader responsible for identifying when the gubida require formal ritual attention.

The Dügü — Calling the Ancestors Home

The dügü is the central Garifuna ceremony, a combined funerary, healing, and ancestor-veneration rite that can last from two days to as long as two weeks, organized and directed in every detail — food, ceremonial dress, sacrificial offerings, and duration — by the presiding buyei. The ceremony is understood specifically as a means of curing illness believed to result from a gubida's displeasure: families and community members gather around drummers and singers who call the ancestral spirits into the ceremonial space, and the rite concludes when the afflicted person formally receives food and drink on the ancestors' behalf, after which the remaining offerings are ritually given over entirely and the patient is understood to be healed.

Beyond its immediate healing function, the dügü has become an increasingly important vehicle of Garifuna political and cultural visibility, particularly amid the community's ongoing land rights struggles described below; the ceremony's continued, undisrupted performance — notably including a significant contemporary revival centered in Livingston, Guatemala — functions simultaneously as sacred obligation and as a public assertion of Garifuna cultural continuity and ethnic identity.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

For the Maya, the 260-day sacred calendar continues to structure not only formal ceremony but everyday decision-making, naming, and personal reflection, with day-keepers consulted by community members for guidance much as a counselor or spiritual advisor would be consulted in other traditions, integrating calendrical cosmology directly into ordinary daily life and personal wellbeing.

For Taíno revival practitioners, cohoba and tobacco ceremony, alongside a broader practice of treating the natural world as conscious and relational (a stance practitioners describe as engaging a 'world alive'), function as both spiritual discipline and a framework for psychological and community healing amid the historical trauma of near-total colonial demographic collapse.

For the Garifuna, the dügü's healing function is understood as inseparable from its communal and familial dimension: illness is treated not as an individual, isolated condition but as a disruption in relationship with the ancestors requiring the whole extended family and community's active participation to resolve — a model of health as fundamentally relational and social rather than purely biomedical.

Legacy and Influence

Maya calendrical and astronomical achievement remains recognized as among the most sophisticated systems developed in the pre-modern world, and living Maya language communities, numbering in the millions across Guatemala, Mexico, and Belize, continue active efforts at language and ceremonial preservation, supported in part by UNESCO's 2012 recognition of the Popol Vuh.

The Taíno revival movement has produced a growing body of publicly visible cultural institutions, museum exhibitions (including the Smithsonian's 2019 'We Are Still Here' exhibition), and community organizations across Puerto Rico and the diaspora, substantially shifting mainstream historical narrative away from a simple extinction account.

Garifuna language, music (notably paranda and the UNESCO-recognized garifuna drumming and dance tradition, inscribed on UNESCO's Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2008), and culinary tradition have achieved significant recognition well beyond Central America, and the dügü ceremony itself is increasingly studied as a notable model of resilient Afro-Indigenous religious survival under conditions of forced displacement.

Genocide, Erasure, and Land — Controversies and Fairness

Guatemala's 1960-1996 civil war included a documented campaign of mass violence against Maya communities during the early 1980s, particularly under the military government of Efraín Ríos Montt, later formally found by Guatemalan courts to constitute genocide against the Ixil Maya population specifically; prosecutions have continued into the present, including an April 2024 trial of a former general on genocide charges more than four decades after the war's most violent period, and contemporary Maya communities continue to describe ongoing land dispossession — driven by agribusiness expansion, mining, and large infrastructure projects — as a continuation of the same underlying dispossession by different, non-military means.

The Taíno revival movement has faced sustained academic and public skepticism, with some scholars maintaining that pre-colonial Taíno culture and religion were effectively destroyed within a century of contact and that contemporary revival constitutes a modern reconstruction rather than direct unbroken continuity; revival practitioners and Indigenous rights advocates respond that this 'extinction' framing itself reflects a colonial historiography that erased documented survival, intermarriage, and cultural retention within Puerto Rican, Dominican, and Cuban communities, and that genetic and cultural evidence supports a claim of continuity rather than pure invention — a debate that remains genuinely unresolved in the relevant scholarship.

The Garifuna face an active, ongoing land rights crisis in Honduras, where decades of encroachment by palm oil plantations, tourism development, and hydroelectric projects have persisted despite three favorable rulings from the Inter-American Court of Human Rights affirming Garifuna territorial rights; Honduran institutional weakness and enforcement gaps have prevented full restitution, and Indigenous and Afro-Honduran human rights defenders, including prominent Garifuna land defenders who have received documented death threats, accounted for nearly a third of all human rights defenders attacked in Honduras in 2023. In February 2024, the Honduran government established CIANCSI, a commission tasked with enforcing the outstanding court rulings and restoring ancestral land to three specific Garifuna communities (Triunfo de la Cruz, Punta Piedra, and San Juan); implementation remains in progress and closely monitored by international human rights bodies as of this writing.

Closing

The day-keepers of highland Guatemala still open the Popol Vuh in ceremony. The cohoba is still burned in Taíno revival circles from Puerto Rico to the diaspora in New York. The Garifuna buyei still calls the gubida home, drum by drum, most years, somewhere on the Caribbean coast of Honduras or Belize or Guatemala.

None of these three peoples asked to be called extinct, or defeated, or gone. None of them are.

Grand rising to the corn people and the island ancestors — the count of days continues, and so do they.